

Summary: Transition from Plan Environmental Impact Assessment to Strategic Environmental Assessment

Authors: Olivia Bina, Ausra Jurkeviciute, and Zhang Hui

Publisher: Stockholm Environment Institute (SEI)

Date: May 2009

What It Is

The final report of the EU-funded CHINA-EPI-SEA project (*Policy Instruments for a Chinese Sustainable Future*), a 27-month collaboration (2007–2009) between four European and four Chinese research institutions, led by the Wuppertal Institute.

Core Topic

How China can evolve its legally-mandated **Plan Environmental Impact Assessment (PEIA)** — as required by China’s EIA Law 2002 — into a fuller, more strategic **Strategic Environmental Assessment (SEA)** aligned with international best practice.

Focus Sectors

Energy and transport, which together account for the bulk of China’s environmental pressure and roughly two-thirds of the government’s RMB 400 trillion stimulus package at the time.

Two Case Studies

- **Shaanxi Province Expressway Plan** (transport)
 - **Xichang City Energy Saving Plan, Sichuan** (energy)
-

Key Findings and Recommendations

1. Current PEIA in China is narrow — it assesses plans after decisions are largely made, limiting its influence.
2. Scoping and public participation are weak; stakeholder consultation is superficial.
3. Monitoring and follow-up after plan approval is poorly developed.
4. The report recommends moving to a more integrated SEA model: earlier in the planning cycle, broader in scope (including alternatives), with stronger public participation and independent review.
5. It calls for further EU-China joint research and capacity building.